



Partly sunny 46/37 • Tomorrow: Mostly sunny 52/28 **B18**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

SATURDAY, DECEMBER 20, 2025 • \$4

A controversial renaming



MARVIN JOSEPH/THE WASHINGTON POST

The Kennedy Center installed President Donald Trump's name on the building's exterior Friday morning. The center's board voted Thursday to rename the institution "The Donald J. Trump and The John F. Kennedy Memorial Center for the Performing Arts," and the president's name was up within 24 hours. **Story, A5**

U.S. plans to stop recommending most vaccines

BY LENA H. SUN
AND RACHEL ROUBEIN

The Trump administration plans to shift the federal government away from directly recommending most vaccines for children and suggest they receive fewer shots to more closely align with Denmark's immunization model, according to two people familiar with the matter.

Federal health officials are weighing vaccine guidance that would encourage parents to talk to a doctor to make decisions for

Approach inspired by Denmark would suggest children get fewer shots

most shots, according to the people, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to describe internal deliberations. This approach would mark a fundamental shift in the U.S. health care system, which generally relies on federal health agencies to guide how pa-

tients are protected against disease.

It was not immediately clear which shots would no longer be recommended. The plans are still in flux, the people said, but broadly align with President Donald Trump's directive earlier this month to consider recommending fewer shots, referring to the United States as an "outlier" among developed countries. He said any changes to the country's vaccine schedule should continue to preserve access to currently available shots.

Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. has been critical of the childhood vaccine schedule for years and has called for additional scrutiny, even though he told senators during his confirmation hearings that he supports the schedule.

Andrew Nixon, a spokesperson for the Department of Health and Human Services, said of the planned revisions to vaccine recommendations: "Unless you hear it from HHS directly, this is pure speculation." The potential shift

SEE VACCINES ON A7

Rebuke follows partial release of Epstein files

DOJ ACTION FALLS SHORT OF LAW'S DEADLINE

Agency cites rigor of review to shield victim identities

BY MARK BERMAN,
JEREMY ROEBUCK
AND PERRY STEIN

The Justice Department on Friday released a huge trove of documents connected to the deceased financier and convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein, partially complying with federal legislation that ordered officials to make public a collection of records long sought by his victims but entangled in political controversy.

The documents' release, just ahead of a deadline imposed by the legislation, marked a closely watched step in the months-long bipartisan push to force Presi-

dent Donald Trump and his administration to disclose more materials related to Epstein, who died in federal custody in 2019 while facing charges of sex-trafficking and abusing girls.

The material released Friday includes a large number of photographs of Epstein and other people, along with other pictures, flight logs and law enforcement records. But the release fell short of the comprehensive disclosures required by the Epstein Files Transparency Act, a law passed last month.

The Justice Department said it needed more time to review records and remove information

SEE EPSTEIN ON A6

U.S. strikes in Syria in retaliation for attack

Operation targets Islamic State infrastructure and weapons storage

BY DAN LAMOTHE
AND TARA COPP

The U.S. military on Friday night launched strikes against dozens of sites in central Syria, U.S. officials said, following an attack last weekend that killed two U.S. soldiers and a civilian interpreter.

The strikes on Islamic State infrastructure and weapons stor-

age locations began at about 4 p.m. Eastern time and hit more than 70 targets, officials said. A-10 attack jets, F-15 and F-16 fighter jets and Apache helicopters were involved along with rocket artillery fired by U.S. forces in the region, said one person familiar with the operation. More than 100 precision munitions were deployed, officials said.

Friday's assault followed a Dec. 13 ambush at a military base in the city of Palmyra that killed two members of the Iowa National Guard — Sgt. Edgar Brian Torres-Tovar, 25, and Sgt. William Nathaniel Howard, 29 — and Ayad Mansoor Sakat, 54, an Iraq-

SEE SYRIA ON A7

Despite push to hold off, U-Va. picks a new president

Beardsley named leader of state's flagship school amid political fight

BY DAN ROSENZWEIG-ZIFF

CHARLOTTESVILLE — The University of Virginia on Friday named its longtime business school dean as the flagship's next president, sparking near-immediate condemnation from some faculty, alumni and state Democrats who wanted the board to wait until Gov.-elect Abigail Spanberger takes office next month.

The move caps a tumultuous year for U-Va., which saw former president James E. Ryan resign this summer amid pressure from the Trump administration over diversity, equity and inclusion policies, as well as protests and jockeying among state politicians over how the institution should move forward.

Scott C. Beardsley, dean of the Darden School of Business since 2015, was unanimously approved as U-Va.'s 10th president during a special meeting of the Board of Visitors, which is full of appointees of Republican Gov. Glenn Youngkin. His contract will begin Jan. 1 and is set to last five and a half years. Further details of the contract will be left to the board's rector.

"It's the honor of my professional life," Beardsley told the board after the vote. "I aspire to no higher office."

Wearing a blue and orange U-Va. tie, he hugged rector Rachel Sheridan to applause and a standing ovation from friends, family and board members in the room.

The Washington Post reported Thursday that Beardsley had emerged as the top candidate in a months-long process that included dozens of applicants but drew concerns from some faculty, students and others over the effectiveness of the school's governing board. After winning in last month's election, Spanberger (D) had asked the board to pause the search.

Ahead of the meeting, a few dozen protesters gathered outside and called for the board members to resign. They held signs reading "pause" and "no confidence, no new president." The anger was largely aimed at what was seen as a rushed selection process, not at Beardsley as the board's pick — though some criticized him for accepting the position when he did.

Virginia Senate President Pro Tem L. Louise Lucas (D-Portsmouth) warned Beardsley that the legislature controls much of the university's funds.

"Buckle up," she wrote on social media.

Ryan, who led U-Va. for nearly

SEE VIRGINIA ON A15

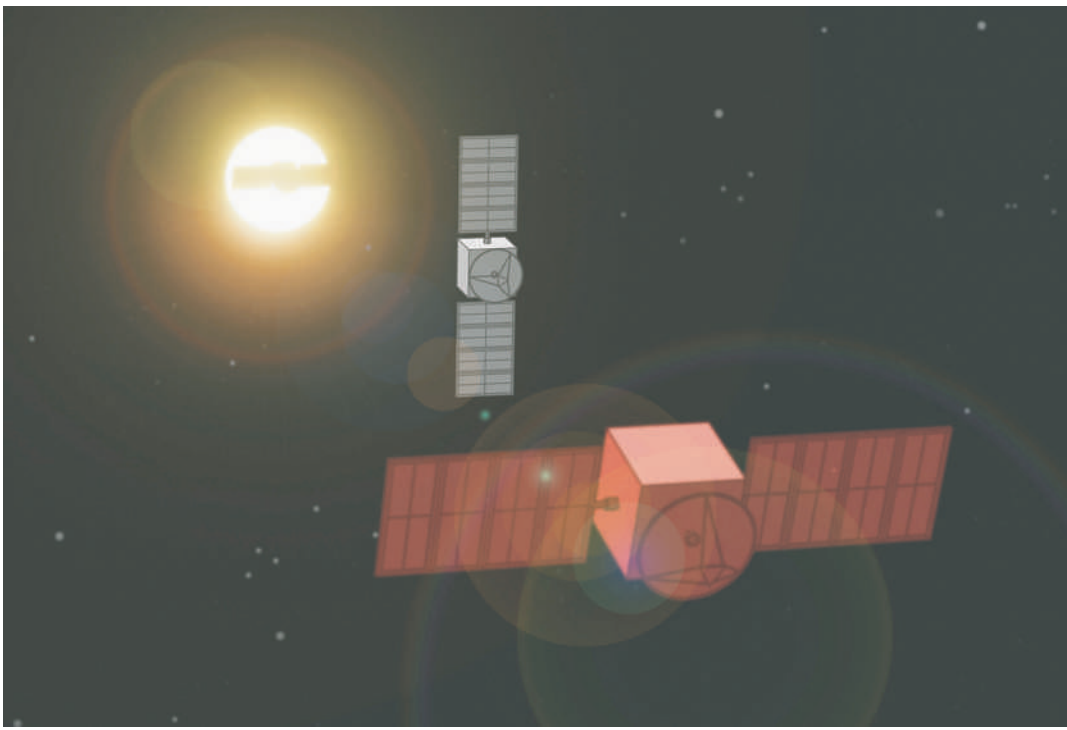


ILLUSTRATION BY AARON STECKELBERG/THE WASHINGTON POST

Far above Earth, a satellite 'dogfight'

U.S., Chinese spacecraft routinely spy on each other as tensions rise

BY CHRISTIAN DAVENPORT,
AARON STECKELBERG
AND WILLIAM NEFF

The American patrol satellite had the targets in its sights: two recently launched Chinese spacecraft flying through one of the most sensitive neighborhoods in space. Like any good tactical fighter, the American spacecraft, known as USA 270, ap-

proached from behind, so that the sun would be at its back, illuminating the quarry.

But then one of the Chinese satellites countered by slowing down. As USA 270 zipped by, the Chinese satellite dropped in behind its American pursuer, like Maverick's signature "hit-the-brakes" move in the movie "Top Gun." The positions reversed, U.S. officials controlling their spacecraft

from Earth were forced to plot their next move.

The encounter some 22,000 miles above Earth in 2022 was never acknowledged publicly by the Pentagon or Beijing. Happening out of sight and little noticed except by space and defense specialists, this kind of orbital skirmishing has become so common that defense officials now refer to it as

SEE SPACE ON A8

MIT slaying victim, Brown suspect were former peers

This article is by Joanna Slater,
Catarina Fernandes Martins,
Aaron C. Davis, David Ovalle
and Jeremy Roebuck

The two young men were peers, brilliant aspiring scientists working toward a degree at Portugal's most prestigious engineering school, a white building at the top of a grassy plaza in Lisbon.

A quarter-century later, both were in the United States, but their paths had diverged radically.

Nuno Loureiro was a physics professor at the Massachusetts Institute of Technology, a beloved mentor who researched the behavior of plasmas. Claudio Neves Valente was living in Miami, his scientific career long discarded.

On Monday, Valente hunted down Loureiro, authorities said, shooting him at the home he shared with his wife and three daughters near Boston. Loureiro died early the next day.

For Valente, it was the second act in a deadly rampage that began at Brown University 48 hours earlier, when he burst into a lecture hall and opened fire, authorities said, killing two undergraduates in an economics study session.

Valente subsequently killed

SEE SHOOTING ON A4

IN THE NEWS

Putin ridicules Europe In his year-end show, the Russian leader said the U.S. is more Moscow-friendly and expressed confidence about the Ukraine war. A11

Racism in schools Parents in a Texas city say incidents are increasing as the Trump administration backs off investigations. A3

THE NATION
In towns across the South, redneck Christmas parades are taking the spotlight. The term, originally used as a slur, has been co-opted and transformed into a point of pride for many. A18

THE WORLD
Gaza is still seeing acute malnutrition but not famine, a hunger monitor said. A12
Australia will establish a gun buyback program after the fatal Bondi Beach attack. A13

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Political groups with the backing of tech investors and Meta plan to fend off AI regulation by intervening in 2026 races. A10

STYLE
"The Housemaid" is an absurd thriller, but it may also be a secret feminist masterpiece. B1
SPORTS
Commanders linebacker Bobby Wagner is nearing 2,000 regular season career tackles, a testament to his dedication to the craft. B7

THE REGION
House Oversight Democrats blasted their GOP counterparts for a report claiming that D.C. police covered up crimes. B13
A Tennessee man has played Santa in Virginia for 37 years. It's not an easy gig, but the joy of the experience keeps bringing him back. B13

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